

Ex OnePlus co-founder, Carl Pei's new venture dubbed "Nothing" has generated quite a bit of buzz in the tech community. The company's mission is to remove the barriers between people and technology, and the first product from the newly-founded company is the Nothing Ear 1. We spoke to Manu Sharma, VP and GM, Nothing India, to learn more about the company and the Nothing Ear 1.

d The Nothing Ear 1 sports an innovative transparent design that's seen very rarely, especially in the sub 10K category of TWS earphones. What were some of the challenges the company faced to bring this design to fruition?

Manu: First and foremost, when we were building this product, we wanted to be very gutsy and bold in our approach. Transparency sounds very cool, but it's also extremely difficult because of all the aspects of that. So when it came to designing, the first challenge was the material itself. One of the feedbacks from India was that plastic can become dirty and yellow. So, the team ensured that we used a IHP rating material which is extremely robust. For example, it takes 30 times more force to scratch this material versus the ones on the market. We had to work with various suppliers making sure that we're choosing the right material. We also worked with various suppliers to put it together. In fact, many suppliers said that we can't do this, we haven't seen anything like this before, we can do run off the mill stuff. But we were able to share our vision and what we wanted to achieve and finally we were able to work with some suppliers who worked with us solidly to make sure we put together the things needed. With transparency, you can see the magnets, the circuit board, and the microphones on our product. All of this requires that the product be not just beautiful to look at from the outside, but also the inside. So, a lot of work needed to be done even internally for the various components. For example, the magnets (in earphones) are typically never polished or given shape. But we had to get them polished and given shape so that it gels with the overall design. It's been a great learning journey for us as well. Building a transparent material product is not for the faint-hearted, it requires a lot of resilience. We're proud of what we've finally got together.

Nothing creates something special



Manu Sharma,
Vice President and General Manager,
Nothing India

Learn more about the
newly-founded company
Nothing and its first product
– The Nothing Ear 1

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d As we've come to gather, Nothing is extremely dedicated to bringing a unique design to their products. This will obviously mean having to use different materials and components than what the status quo in the industry is. So, have there been any compromises made on the tech front to achieve this design language?

Manu: The only compromise we've made is that we've spent a lot more time than we had anticipated internally. And that's why Carl also announced that the launch date will be pushed since the transparent material is very difficult to deal with. We had to work with our assemblers since it's a learning curve for them as well. So, the compromises for the consumer are absolutely nothing. From our side, we've put a lot of effort into building this product.

d The Nothing Ear 1 costs \$99 in the US, but in India, it's priced considerably lower at ₹5,999. So, is the unit the exact same? If yes, what sparked the decision of pricing it lower in India?

Manu: First and foremost, the unit is exactly the same, there's no difference between the global product and the one launched in India. We wanted to get the product in India from the first date of launch itself and we have announced our partnership with Flipkart for selling the product online. This also allows us to save cost in the operating side, so we want to pass

that benefit to the consumer by pricing it very sweetly. Pricing is not the main driver for us, it's about providing an absolutely iconic design, and great user experience in terms of simplicity of usage as well.

d What about products outside the audio space? Will Nothing be venturing into other kinds of products and what can our readers expect from Nothing in the future?

Manu: So, our mission is to launch a complete ecosystem of connected devices and we want to remove the barriers between people and technology. We are a global company headquartered in the UK and our design is all out of Sweden. So, we want to venture out and bring about a lot of different categories of products other than audio as well. As we move forward, we will reveal more about our new pipeline of products as well. **d**